third countries. India had security commitments to Bhutan dating from the 1949 Bhutan India Treaty of Friendship, which had been updated in 2007. These included training and support for the Royal Bhutan Army. [25] India was also conscious that Chinese encroachment into Bhutanese territory would have potentially severe consequences for Indian security in the Siliguri Corridor in the south. Although the Doklam stand-off was resolved after a tense two months—just prior to a Party Congress in China and a BRICS Summit—it led to both China and India reinforcing their military positions in the vicinity. In contrast to prior border stand-offs in 2013 and 2014—in which India had angrily criticized Chinese provocations—the Doklam stand-off also gave a preview of China's rhetorical belligerence and war-mongering. Another effect was greater public debate in Bhutan about relations with India and China. [26]

After 2018, efforts were made at improving high-level engagement between New Delhi and Beijing. Modi and Xi took part in an 'informal summit' at Wuhan, and Modi reciprocated in 2019 by inviting Xi to Mamallapuram near Chennai. Yet, despite a rhetorical cooling of temperatures, neither side made significant progress or concessions to the other. The most significant material benefits were minor adjustments to trade in specific goods. Developments in 2019 and 2020 were to reveal the hollowness of some of these high-level diplomatic engagements.

Modi's early diplomatic frustrations with China contrasted with a warm visit to the United States almost immediately after Xi's 2014 visit to India, despite having previously had his visa denied by Washington as chief minister of Gujarat. In addition to being feted by the White House and State Department during his 2014 visit, Modi headlined a massive event for the diaspora at Madison Square Garden in New York City. Such diaspora engagements would become a hallmark of Modi's political and foreign policy outreach, with similar events later organized in London, Sydney, and Houston, among other places. Modi's visit also soon translated into a reciprocal one to India by US President Barack Obama. Not only did Obama become the first US president to visit India twice in his tenure, but he became the first American leader to be hosted for Republic Day. One of